

C3 – PROTECTING SENIORS & DISABLED VS COLA REALITY

(Contradictions Ledger – Evidence Sheet)

I. THE OFFICIAL NARRATIVE ("WORDS")

Federal officials frequently claim that COLA protects seniors and disabled Americans from inflation, saying benefits "keep up with expenses," provide "breathing room," and support "economic dignity." Statements also emphasize that benefits "reflect today's economic realities," suggesting COLA adjustments are adequate.

II. HOUSEHOLD OUTCOMES ("OUTCOMES")

1. Record Senior Housing Cost Burden

Harvard Joint Center for Housing Studies reports more than 12 million older households pay over 30 percent of income toward housing, and millions pay more than half. This contradicts claims that benefits keep pace with the cost of living.

2. Senior Poverty

The Supplemental Poverty Measure (SPM) for seniors is significantly higher than the official rate, reflecting medical and housing costs not captured in traditional measures.

3. Medicare Premium Pressure

Medicare Part B premiums continue rising and routinely consume large portions of COLA increases, reducing actual take-home benefit gains.

4. Elderly Inflation (CPI-E) vs Worker Inflation (CPI-W)

COLA is tied to CPI-W, which reflects worker spending patterns. CPI-E, reflecting elderly spending patterns, is consistently higher due to medical and housing costs. This means COLA undercompensates seniors.

5. Long-Run Buying Power Erosion

Analyses indicate Social Security benefits have lost around 20 percent of buying power since 2010 because COLA fails to track true senior inflation.

III. THE CONTRADICTION

Leaders claim COLA protects purchasing power. However, government data shows rising poverty, higher housing costs, medical premiums reducing checks, and long-term erosion of real benefit value.

Short statement: COLA is presented as protection, but seniors lose ground each year.

IV. HARM CHANNELS

- Income erosion over time.
- Housing insecurity and rising rent burdens.
- Increased medical cost strain.
- Higher food insecurity.

- Compounding loss of real income for long-lived retirees.

V. APA ROUTING (AGENCY USE)

- vSSA: COLA formula mismatch (CPI-W vs CPI-E).
- vHUD: Senior housing burden contradicts affordability assurances.
- vFED: Senior inflation higher than aggregate inflation.
- vHHS/CMS: Medicare costs undermining COLA.
- vIRS: Indexing failing to match real senior inflation.

This sheet establishes evidence of a consistent mismatch between official COLA claims and senior living costs.